

Council Meeting
January 8, 2025
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The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, January 8, 2025, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor William Greenrose
At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Yoshi Manale, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor O’Hearne to accept the minutes of the December 12, 2024, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

MAYOR'S NOTES

Ribbon cutting ceremony for Wendy's this Friday at 10:00 a.m.

The Senior Center is hosting a turkey dinner on January 18th. Reservations are needed.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Acuity Recycling Services, Inc. Update: a public hearing has been scheduled for February 6th, 2025 at 6:00 p.m. in Claremont City Hall. Public Comment Section is open until January 20th for the receipt of written comments to be included in the public hearing record.

Last month Sullivan County Community Power presented the community power plan to the public, the County hopes to join the New Hampshire Community Power Coalition to provide opt in for those within Sullivan County who would like the potential lower electrical rates offered by community power. Several communities in Sullivan County have already committed to community power as the default rate. However, Claremont is still considering this option.

Claremont Savings Bank Community Center has a new scoreboard provided by GKN Aero Space.

There was a well-attended First Night event coordinated by Sugar River Rotary and location participation from Maple Lanes, Daddy's Pizza, and the Arrowhead Recreation Club. This event could not have happened without the sponsorship from Bar Harbor Bank and Trust, Claremont Savings Bank, Ross and Sam's, 21st Century High View Realty, Marrow's Home Center, and Healthy Connections.

On Friday Manager Manale will be dropping off the City's Original Charter. The City received a Moose Plate Grant for its preservation.

Assistant Mayor Matteau gave a shout out to the first responders that worked on New Year's Eve Police, Fire, and Golden Cross, stating the response to the accident was professionally handled, fast, and wanted to thank them.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Council appointments

Mayor Girard stated there is a one-year appointment open for CCTV, and asked if any other councilors were interested, Councilor Zutter volunteered.

CCTV

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Limoges to appoint Councilor Zutter to the CCTV Board.

Voice vote:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0**

Zoning Board

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to appoint Councilor Heminway to Seat 4 of the Zoning Board.

Voice vote:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0**

Claremont Development Authority

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to re-appoint Andre Lafreniere to seat 3 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O’Hearne to re-appoint Robert Porter to Seat 2 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to re-appoint Keith Raymond to seat 1 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

Mayor Girard listed the concerns of eligibility for Mr. Tremblay to be on the Police Commission as he is the City’s Building Inspector, and reached out to NHMA for clarification. Mayor Girard read the email received from NHMA out loud, both candidates were asked to speak.

Mark Limoges, Ward 3, stated he was born and raised in Claremont and is heavily invested in this City, and wants to help move the City forward. He also noted his long-time management experience.

Joel Tremblay, Ward 2, City employee Building Inspector and Health Officer noted he has lived in Claremont for 19 years and was previously on the Police Commission for three full terms and would like to be a part of the Commission again, and mentioned his management capacity.

Councilor Greenrose asked Mr. Tremblay if he was employed by the City when previously on the Police Commission, Mr. Tremblay replied, no.

Councilor O’Hearne asked if there had been any other City employee on this board before, and if Mr. Tremblay felt there was a conflict of interest, Mr. Tremblay replied, no.

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to appoint Mark Limoges to Seat 2 of the Claremont Police Commission.

A motion was made by Councilor Zutter and seconded by Councilor Hayden to appoint Joel Tremblay to Seat 2 of the Claremont Police Commission.

Assistant Mayor Matteau expressed this seemed sticky and wants separation of employee and board member.

Councilor Koloski agreed.

Roll call:
Koloski – Limoges
Greenrose – Limoges
Limoges - Limoges
Matteau – Limoges
Zutter – Tremblay
Hemingway – Limoges
Hayden – Tremblay

O’Hearne – Limoges

Girard – Limoges

Motion carried 7-2 in Favor of Mark Limoges

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen’s forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you’d like to be contacted as well as your concern on the clipboard for follow up.

No one spoke, Mayor Girard closed Citizens Forum.

NEW BUSINESS

Fund Balance Policy

Director Bates explained the changes for the fund balance.

Mayor Girard thinks it’s great to have it spelled out, but concerned for the wording on the last page section 4.

Councilor Hayden agrees with percentage number but noted catastrophes can happen and 5% is a small number, and would like a bigger buffer.

Director Bates noted the fund balance cannot be spent without Council approval.

Mayor Girard suggested removing the paragraph. Director Bates stated being comfortable with this.

Council agrees to take the Paragraph out.

Motion to Adopt Revised Fund Balance Policy

The Claremont City Council, in accordance with Governmental Accounting Standards Board Statement (GASB) 54, *Fund Balance Reporting and Governmental Fund Types Definitions*,

hereby adopts the revised Fund Balance Policy and authorizes the City Manager or his designees to take such actions as may be necessary to implement said Fund Balance Policy in accordance with applicable federal and state law, regulation and policy.

A motion was made by Councilor Greenrose and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to adopt the Fund Balance Policy as amended.

Roll call:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0**

Investment Policy Review

Director Bates noted this is supposed to be an annual motion and updated the language with new RSA numbers.

Motion to Adopt City Investment Policy

The Claremont City Council, pursuant to RSA 47:6 and RSA 48:16, hereby re-adopts the City of Claremont Investment Policy and authorizes the City Manager or his designees to take such actions as may be necessary to implement said Investment Policy in accordance with state law and regulation.

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Limoges to adopt the City Investment Policy.

Roll call:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes**

Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

Code of Conduct Policy Discussion

Policy Chairman, Councilor Hemingway, stated the Policy Committee reviewed this policy for Council and Boards and Committee members.

Councilor Koloski asked if this Policy was based on another community.

Councilor Heminway noted it was based off of Dorchester.

Councilor O’Hearne asked how this came to be, Councilor Hemingway stated the Council agreed to this following the removal of a committee member.

Assistant Mayor Matteau stated not recalling directing the Policy Committee to review the Code of Conduct, and shared her feelings on the revised Policy. Assistant Mayor Matteau stated the Charter and Council rules already cover the Council and doesn’t want to add another layer.

Councilor Zutter appreciates comments from Assistant Mayor Matteau, and noted this does not restrict anyone from posting on social media.

Councilor Hayden stated this was a fantastic document, and this can be more of a guide and this will also protect citizens with accountability to the Councilors that are elected.

Councilor Limoges thinks it’s too subjective, and is against limiting freedom of speech.

Councilor O’Hearne shared concern with this policy covering boards and committees as the Planning Board is governed by an RSA.

Councilor Greenrose mentioned there is nothing in the policy that isn’t ethical common sense, and said it’s better to have something in place.

Councilor Hemingway tried to clarify this is just a discussion, and the Policy Committee can always go back and review or change anything in this document.

Assistant Mayor Matteau asked to see a copy of our current code of conduct.

Councilor O’Hearne asked if there was any legal input.

Councilor Hemingway stated yes, an attorney came in to give the Policy Committee ideas.

Councilor Koloski shared major concern for legal counsel and noted the Policy Committee shouldn't be meeting with legal without permission from Council, then stated the document was embarrassing.

Mayor Girard also commented that an attorney shouldn't have been involved.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to not approve the Code of Conduct Policy as presented and bring back to a future Council meeting with the current code of conduct, charter provisions, and council rules to review.

Councilor Zutter stated being offended with these comments, and noted a lot of effort went into this.

Roll call:

Koloski – no

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – no

Hemingway – no

Hayden – no

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 5-4

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Limoges reported for the CDA, and noted service link gave notice to vacate Tremont Street. The roof was looked at for the arts center.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted the Planning Committee meets Monday, and the Sub Committee will have a discussion on chickens at the next meeting.

Councilor Hemingway mentioned the bicycle ordinance is being reviewed by the Policy Committee.

Councilor Hayden stated the Conservation Commission's last meeting was on the Slaughter House before it went to the Zoning Board.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Councilor Limoges would like to have a department head meeting for The Wall That Heals with Police, Fire, Parks, and DPW.

Councilor Koloski thanked whoever gives out the Planning Board Packets.

Councilor Koloski would like clearer definitions of the Policy Committee or motion to disband it.

Councilor Koloski wants the audio in the microphones in Council Chambers turned up.

Councilor Hayden would like to discuss an ice-skating rink; Manager Manale noted the Parks and Recreation Department is looking into this.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:42 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to adjourn.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council